

Learning to Stay on Your Path

Sections 1 & 2

Vocabulary, Grammar, and Comprehension Handout

Intermediate Level

THE TEXT

Section 1: You Don't Actually Want Everything

Lately, I've been thinking a lot about this journey we've been on together. What started as a small idea — sharing English, thoughts, and quiet reflections — has slowly grown into something that feels truly meaningful. Every message, every comment, every moment you chose to listen has become part of this path.

And now we're getting closer to 100,000 subscribers, which still feels a little unreal to say out loud. I feel grateful, excited... and also reflective. Because growth doesn't always feel loud or confident. Sometimes it feels quiet, slow, and surprisingly fragile.

When you work on something for a long time, often behind the scenes, you don't always notice the progress right away. And yet, even when things are moving forward, there are moments where doubt quietly appears — not because something is wrong, but simply because you care.

Have you ever been working toward something quietly... and then suddenly felt unsure — even though nothing actually went wrong?

Maybe it happened in a very normal moment. You're sitting at a café. You bring your notebook. You write down a few goals. They make sense to you. They feel realistic. Calm. Then you look around. At the next table, someone is talking confidently in English with a foreign client. On the other side, a group is discussing their startup idea. Someone else looks busy, focused, important. You look back at your notebook. And your goal suddenly feels... small.

I've noticed something in myself in moments like that. I don't suddenly want to quit. I don't suddenly hate my path. I just start thinking: "Maybe I should aim higher." "Maybe this is too simple." "Maybe I'm not thinking big enough."

Sometimes we don't leave our path because it's wrong. We leave because it doesn't look impressive enough.

We say we want growth. We say we want improvement. But often, what we really want is reassurance that we are moving fast enough. And speed is very visible in other people. But progress on your own path? That's private. Quiet. Invisible.

I once met a young woman who told me she had been learning English for almost a year. Slowly. Consistently. She wasn't fluent. She wasn't advanced. But she showed up every week. One day she attended a networking event. She heard someone speak perfectly. That night she told herself, "I'm so behind. Maybe I should try something else." Nothing changed about her effort. Only her comparison did. And that comparison almost erased one year of quiet discipline.

Staying on your path requires something simple but difficult: You have to decide what matters before the world tells you what should matter.

Most people don't fail by choosing wrong. They fail by choosing too many times. And sometimes, the bravest thing you can do... is stay.

Section 2: The Small Decisions That Move You Sideways

You rarely wake up and say, "I'm going to leave my path today." It doesn't happen like that. It happens in quiet, reasonable decisions.

You plan to practice English after work. Nothing big. Just twenty minutes. You even feel slightly proud that you're being consistent. But the day feels long. Your body feels heavy. You tell yourself, "I'll just sit down for five minutes first." You make tea. You look at your to-do list. You rearrange something small on your desk. You're not avoiding. You're preparing.

Then you think, “Maybe I should finish that small task first so my mind feels clear.” That small task becomes two. Then three. By the time you open your notebook, your energy is lower. Your focus is thinner. And the voice appears: “I’ll do it properly tomorrow.” Nothing dramatic happened. But you moved sideways.

I’ve noticed something uncomfortable in my own life. The days I drift away from what matters to me are not chaotic days. They are organized days filled with small, practical actions. That’s what makes it tricky. Because everything you did was reasonable. You answered emails. You helped someone. You cleaned something. You stayed busy. But you didn’t move forward.

Sideways movement feels productive. That’s why it’s hard to detect.

We think abandoning our path will look like laziness. But often it looks like responsibility. You’re doing things. You’re just not doing the right things.

There was a period when I wanted to build a steady reading habit again. Just ten pages a day. The first week went well. The second week, I missed one evening. It felt small. The third week, I missed two days because I was “catching up” on other tasks. By the fourth week, I still told myself I cared — but I hadn’t opened the book in days. I didn’t quit. I postponed. And postponing is quiet. No announcement. No decision. Just delay.

It took me almost two months to admit something simple: I was giving my best energy to urgent things, not meaningful ones. Urgent feels loud. Someone needs a reply. A task has a deadline. A message feels immediate. Meaningful is quiet. It waits. Your path is usually quiet. It doesn’t demand. It doesn’t shout. It just sits there, waiting for you to return.

Someone once wrote to me saying she keeps planning her study schedule perfectly — color-coded, detailed — but rarely follows it for more than a week. Not because she lacks desire. But because something “more important” always appears. When we talked deeper, she realized something painful. Nothing more important appeared. Only more immediate. And immediate wins when you don’t protect your direction.

Staying on your path requires small protection. Not big motivation. Not dramatic discipline. Protection. Protection of twenty minutes. Protection of one page. Protection of one quiet

effort. Because sideways doesn't feel dangerous. But repeated sideways steps can take you far from where you meant to go.

PART A: VOCABULARY (12 Words)

Study the following vocabulary words from the text. Pay attention to how each word is used in context.

#	Word	Definition & Example from Text
1	reflection (n.)	careful thought about something. <i>"Sharing English, thoughts, and quiet reflections."</i>
2	fragile (adj.)	easily broken or damaged; delicate. <i>"Sometimes it feels quiet, slow, and surprisingly fragile."</i>
3	doubt (n.)	a feeling of not being certain or sure about something. <i>"There are moments where doubt quietly appears."</i>
4	reassurance (n.)	words or actions that make someone feel less worried. <i>"What we really want is reassurance that we are moving fast enough."</i>
5	discipline (n.)	the ability to keep doing something regularly, even when it is difficult. <i>"That comparison almost erased one year of quiet discipline."</i>
6	consistent (adj.)	doing something regularly without stopping; steady. <i>"You even feel slightly proud that you're being consistent."</i>
7	drift (v.)	to move slowly away from something without planning to. <i>"The days I drift away from what matters to me are not chaotic days."</i>
8	detect (v.)	to notice or discover something that is not easy to see. <i>"That's why it's hard to detect."</i>

9	abandon (v.)	to give up something completely; to leave behind. <i>"We think abandoning our path will look like laziness."</i>
10	postpone (v.)	to delay something to a later time. <i>"I didn't quit. I postponed."</i>
11	urgent (adj.)	needing immediate attention or action. <i>"I was giving my best energy to urgent things, not meaningful ones."</i>
12	protect (v.)	to keep something safe from harm or loss. <i>"Immediate wins when you don't protect your direction."</i>

Vocabulary Practice 1: Multiple Choice

Choose the best word to complete each sentence.

1. She had no _____ that she would pass the test — she had studied hard and felt ready.
 - a) discipline
 - b) doubt
 - c) reflection
 - d) reassurance
2. The old bridge looked _____, as if it could collapse at any moment.
 - a) urgent
 - b) consistent
 - c) fragile
 - d) detective
3. After much _____, he decided to change his career and become a teacher.
 - a) reassurance
 - b) discipline
 - c) doubt
 - d) reflection
4. The police used security cameras to _____ the source of the problem.
 - a) abandon
 - b) detect
 - c) postpone
 - d) drift
5. Learning a musical instrument requires daily practice and _____.
 - a) reassurance
 - b) doubt
 - c) discipline
 - d) reflection
6. They decided to _____ the picnic because of the heavy rain.

- a) protect
- b) abandon
- c) drift
- d) postpone

7. She needed some _____ from her friends before she felt confident enough to apply.

- a) reassurance
- b) discipline
- c) doubt
- d) reflection

8. If you are not careful, you may slowly _____ away from your original goals.

- a) detect
- b) protect
- c) postpone
- d) drift

9. He had to _____ the project halfway through because he ran out of money.

- a) postpone
- b) abandon
- c) drift
- d) detect

10. Parents naturally want to _____ their children from danger.

- a) detect
- b) abandon
- c) postpone
- d) protect

Vocabulary Practice 2: Fill in the Blanks

Complete each sentence with the correct word from the box.

fragile consistent doubt reflection discipline

1. After a long period of _____, she realized she had been too hard on herself.
2. Being _____ with your study habits is more important than studying for hours in one day.
3. The glass ornament was so _____ that even a light touch could break it.
4. Years of _____ helped him become one of the top athletes in the country.
5. There is no _____ that hard work eventually leads to results.

urgent detect drift protect postpone reassurance

6. She wore sunscreen every day to _____ her skin from the sun.
7. The doctor sent an _____ message asking the patient to come in immediately.
8. Without a clear plan, it is easy to _____ from one idea to the next.
9. His kind words gave her the _____ she needed to keep going.
10. They had to _____ the outdoor concert due to the approaching storm.

PART B: GRAMMAR (4 Patterns)

Study the following grammar structures from the text.

Pattern 1: "What started as... has (slowly) grown into..."

Form: What started as + noun phrase + has (slowly) grown into + noun phrase

Use: To describe something that began in one way and gradually developed into something bigger or different.

Example from text: *"What started as a small idea — sharing English, thoughts, and quiet reflections — has slowly grown into something that feels truly meaningful."*

More examples:

- What started as a hobby has grown into a successful full-time business.
- What started as a short conversation has slowly grown into a deep friendship.
- What started as a simple blog has grown into a popular online community.

Pattern 2: "By the time + subject + verb, ..."

Form: By the time + subject + present/past verb, + subject + will have / had + past participle

Use: To describe a situation that exists or will exist at the point when another action happens.

Example from text: *"By the time you open your notebook, your energy is lower."*

More examples:

- By the time she arrived at the station, the train had already left.
- By the time you finish this course, you will have learned over 300 new words.
- By the time he noticed the mistake, it was too late to fix it.

Pattern 3: Gerund as subject

Form: Verb-ing (+ object/complement) + verb + ...

Use: To use a verb in its -ing form as the subject of a sentence, describing an activity or concept.

Example from text: *"Staying on your path requires something simple but difficult. / Postponing is quiet."*

More examples:

- Learning a new language takes time and patience.
- Running every morning has improved my health.
- Reading before bed helps me fall asleep faster.

Pattern 4: "even when" for concessive clauses

Form: Main clause + even when + subject + verb / Even when + subject + verb, + main clause

Use: To say that something remains true despite a difficult or contrasting condition.

Example from text: *"Even when things are moving forward, there are moments where doubt quietly appears."*

More examples:

- She kept smiling even when the situation was difficult.
- Even when he feels tired, he never skips his morning exercise.
- Good friends support each other even when they disagree.

Grammar Practice 1: Multiple Choice

Choose the best answer to complete each sentence.

1. What started as a hobby _____ a successful full-time business.
 - a) has grown into
 - b) has grown up
 - c) has grown from
 - d) has grown over
2. By the time she _____ to the airport, her flight had already departed.
 - a) gets
 - b) got
 - c) will get
 - d) getting
3. _____ a new language takes time and patience.
 - a) Learn
 - b) Learned
 - c) Learning
 - d) To learning
4. He continued to support his team, even when they _____ every game that season.
 - a) lose
 - b) losing
 - c) lost
 - d) have lost
5. What started as a small disagreement _____ a serious argument.
 - a) has grown from
 - b) has grown into
 - c) has grown up
 - d) has grown over
6. By the time the firefighters arrived, the neighbors _____ most of the people out of the building.

- a) help
- b) helped
- c) had helped
- d) have helped

7. _____ regularly is one of the best ways to stay healthy.

- a) Exercise
- b) Exercised
- c) Exercising
- d) To exercised

8. She stayed calm even when everyone around her _____.

- a) panics
- b) was panicking
- c) will panic
- d) had been panic

9. By the time you finish reading this book, you _____ over 500 new words.

- a) learn
- b) learned
- c) will have learned
- d) learning

10. _____ in front of a large audience can be frightening for many people.

- a) Speak
- b) Spoke
- c) Spoken
- d) Speaking

Grammar Practice 2: Sentence Transformation

Rewrite each sentence using the pattern indicated in parentheses.

What started as... has grown into...

1. His YouTube channel began as a small project. Now it is a media company with millions of followers. (What started as...)

2. Their friendship began as a casual conversation at a bus stop. Now it is a lifelong bond. (What started as...)

By the time + subject + verb, ...

3. She spent three hours cooking. Then the guests arrived. (By the time...)

4. I will finish my homework. Then you will come back from the store. (By the time...)

Gerund as subject

5. It is not easy to wake up early every day. (Waking up...)

6. It takes courage to speak up when everyone disagrees with you. (Speaking up...)

even when

7. She never stopped smiling. Things were difficult. (She never stopped smiling even when...)

8. He kept running. His legs were aching. (He kept running even when...)

9. Good friends support each other. They don't always agree. (Good friends support each other even when...)

10. She practices the piano every day. She doesn't feel like it. (She practices the piano every day even when...)

PART C: COMPREHENSION QUESTIONS

Answer the following questions based on the text.

Tier 1: Literal Understanding

1. What did the author's journey start as, and what has it grown into?
2. What happened to the young woman at the networking event?
3. According to Section 2, what does the author say about the days when she drifts away from what matters?

Tier 2: Inference & Analysis

4. The author says, "We leave because it doesn't look impressive enough." What does this suggest about why people give up on their goals?
5. Why does the author describe sideways movement as "productive"? What makes it dangerous?
6. What is the difference between "urgent" and "meaningful" as the author uses these ideas in Section 2?

Tier 3: Critical Thinking

7. The author describes how small, reasonable tasks can quietly pull you away from your real goals. Do you think it is possible to be both busy and unproductive at the same time? Why or why not?
8. The author says, "Most people don't fail by choosing wrong. They fail by choosing too many times." Do you agree with this idea? Why or why not?

Tier 4: Personal Response

9. Have you ever been working toward a goal and then felt unsure after seeing someone else's progress? What did you do?
10. Think about your own daily routine. Are there small "sideways" habits that take your time away from what truly matters to you?

PART D: CONVERSATION QUESTIONS

Discuss the following questions with a partner or in small groups. Let the conversation flow naturally from one question to the next.

Theme: Staying Focused on What Matters

1. What is one skill or habit you would like to build this year?
2. What steps are you taking to work toward it, and how often do you practice or work on it?
3. Have you ever started working on a goal like this but gradually stopped without realizing it? What pulled you away?
4. Do you think social media makes it even harder to stay focused on your own goals? How?
5. When you lose motivation in the middle of a long-term goal, what do you usually do to get back on track?
6. Some people say that the hardest part of any goal is not starting — it is continuing. Do you agree? Why or why not?
7. If you could give advice to someone who is about to give up on something important to them, what would you say?

ANSWER KEY

Vocabulary Practice 1: Multiple Choice

1. b) doubt 2. c) fragile 3. d) reflection 4. b) detect 5. c) discipline
6. d) postpone 7. a) reassurance 8. d) drift 9. b) abandon 10. d) protect

Vocabulary Practice 2: Fill in the Blanks

1. reflection 2. consistent 3. fragile 4. discipline 5. doubt
6. protect 7. urgent 8. drift 9. reassurance 10. postpone

Grammar Practice 1: Multiple Choice

1. a) has grown into 2. b) got 3. c) Learning 4. c) lost 5. b) has grown into
6. c) had helped 7. c) Exercising 8. b) was panicking 9. c) will have learned 10. d) Speaking

Grammar Practice 2: Sentence Transformation (Sample Answers)

1. What started as a small YouTube project has grown into a media company with millions of followers.
2. What started as a casual conversation at a bus stop has grown into a lifelong friendship.
3. By the time the guests arrived, she had spent three hours cooking.
4. By the time you come back from the store, I will have finished my homework.
5. Waking up early every day is not easy.
6. Speaking up when everyone disagrees with you takes courage.
7. She never stopped smiling even when things were difficult.
8. He kept running even when his legs were aching.
9. Good friends support each other even when they don't always agree.
10. She practices the piano every day even when she doesn't feel like it.

Comprehension Questions (Sample Answers)

1. The author's journey started as a small idea of sharing English, thoughts, and quiet reflections. It has grown into something truly meaningful, with nearly 100,000 subscribers.
2. The young woman had been learning English slowly and consistently for almost a year. At the networking event, she heard someone speak perfectly and told herself she was "so behind," almost causing her to give up.
3. The author says the days she drifts away are not chaotic days — they are organized days filled with small, practical actions.
4. This suggests that people often give up not because their goal is wrong, but because they compare their progress to others and feel their own path is not impressive enough.

5. The author calls sideways movement “productive” because it involves doing reasonable tasks — answering emails, helping someone, cleaning. It is dangerous because it gives the feeling of being busy without actually moving toward one’s real goals.

6. “Urgent” things demand immediate attention, like replying to a message or meeting a deadline. “Meaningful” things are quiet and patient — they are the goals and habits that truly matter but don’t shout for attention.

7–10. Answers will vary.

Conversation Questions

Answers will vary. These questions are designed for open discussion.